

GALLANT IAS ACADEMY
PRELIMS CUM MAINS BATCH 2027
ANCIENT INDIA
MODULE 7
MAURYAN EMPIRE: QUICK SUMMARY

SOURCES

Source	Coverage
Arthashastra (Kautilya)	Prescriptive text on statecraft, economy, espionage.
Indica (Megasthenes)	Greek ambassador's account: city of Pataliputra, social customs.
Ashokan Edicts	Rock and pillar inscriptions: spread of Dhamma, administration, religious policy.
Archaeology	Punch-marked coins, stupas, polished pillars, remain at Pataliputra.

POLITY AND ADMINISTRATION

- **Centralized monarchy** - King supreme, aided by Mantriparishad (Council of Ministers).
- **Bureaucracy:** Mahamatras (special officers, incl. Dhamma Mahamatras), Amatyas, Rajukas.
- **Provinces:** 4 major (Taxila, Ujjain, Tosali, Suvarnagiri), governed by royal princes/viceroy.
- **Army:** Largest standing army of ancient India (infantry, cavalry, elephants, chariots); described by Megasthenes.
- **Espionage:** Secret agents (Gudhapurushas), network emphasized in Arthashastra.

SOCIETY AND ECONOMY

Society

The Varna system existed but with some mobility; women active in royal and religious spheres; slavery in limited form.

Economy

Area	Key Points
Agrarian Base	Irrigation works; state control over forests, mines and salt.

Trade	Inland and maritime; highway from Pataliputra to Taxila; Roman contacts via ports.
Guilds (Shrenis)	Regulated crafts and commerce; precursors of corporate bodies.
Coins	Silver punch-marked coins - medium of exchange and taxation.

RELIGION

Ruler	Religious Affiliation / Policy
Chandragupta	Jain influence; ended life at Shravanabelagola.
Bindusara	Patronized Ajivikas.
Ashoka	After Kalinga war, adopted Buddhism and propagated Dhamma (ethical code: non-violence, tolerance, welfare). Spread Buddhism to Sri Lanka via Mahinda and Sanghamitta. Dhamma = not sectarian religion, but ethical state policy.

ART AND CULTURE

Domain	Key Examples
Architecture	Pataliputra palace (inspired by Achaemenid-Greek influence). Stupas (Sanchi, Bharhut) enlarged under Ashoka. Rock-cut caves (Barabar) - Ajivika ascetics.
Sculpture	Polished sandstone pillars (Sarnath Lion Capital = National Emblem). Animal capitals, edict pillars.
Craftsmanship	Mauryan polish; use of Chunar sandstone.

LEGACY

- **First pan-Indian empire** (except deep South and some North-East).
- **Ashoka's Dhamma:** Prototype of ethical kingship; emphasis on welfare state.
- **Cultural integration:** Helped spread Buddhism abroad - Central Asia, Sri Lanka, SE Asia.
- **Decline after Ashoka** due to weak successors, administrative over-centralization, and invasions (Pushyamitra Shunga).

HISTORIOGRAPHY

Historian	View
R.S. Sharma	Centralized empire with state control on economy.
Romila Thapar	Ashoka's Dhamma as pragmatic, not purely religious.
Burton Stein	Segmentary state model (local autonomy despite imperial claims).

SYSTEM OF GOVERNANCE

"The Mauryan administrative system reflects a high degree of centralization but also shows elements of decentralization." Discuss.

Introduction

- Mauryan Empire (4th-2nd century BCE) - First pan-Indian state.
- Administrative system described in Arthashastra, Indica (Megasthenes), and Ashokan edicts.

Body

Centralized Features	Detail
King as supreme authority	All powers in the person of the ruler (R.S. Sharma).
Council of Ministers (Mantriparishad)	Assisted but remained subordinate to king.
Central Departments (Adhyakshas)	Superintendents of commerce, mines, weights and measures (Arthashastra).
Revenue Administration	Samaharta (chief collector), Sannidhata (treasurer) ensured direct central control.
Standing Army	Overseen by a six-board committee (Megasthenes).

Decentralized Features	Detail
Provincial Governors (Kumaras/Mahamatyas)	Often royal princes ruling large regions (Upinder Singh).

Rajukas	District officers empowered with magisterial and judicial functions; Ashoka's edicts mention their autonomy.
Pradesikas and Yuktas	Local record-keepers, tax collectors - decentralization at district/village level.
Gramika (village headman)	Maintained order and revenue at village level.

Balance of Power

According to Romila Thapar, the Mauryan state had a "centralized bureaucracy with local nodes", ensuring efficiency across vast territories.

Conclusion

- The Mauryan administration combined centralized authority (king + bureaucracy) with decentralized field officials to integrate diverse regions.
- Legacy: Set precedent for later Indian polities in balancing central power with local autonomy.

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